

Q Is there anything I should do now that I know I am pregnant?

These practical steps are some of the first things to do on your pregnancy journey.

- » Make an appointment with your doctor
- » Start taking 400mcg folic acid a day (available from a pharmacy) if you're not already taking it
- » Limit caffeine and avoid drinking alcohol, smoking, and taking drugs (see p.53)
- » Eat healthily
- » Exercise moderately
- » Find ways to relax
- » Become informed by reading about the stages of pregnancy, how your baby is developing, and understanding the tests and ultrasounds you will get in the coming months.

Q I didn't plan to get pregnant, but I am. What should I do?

You are probably deep in shock at the news, but it's worthwhile to remember that many women have mixed emotions when they find out they are pregnant, even when it is planned. First, take the pressure off yourself and your partner, if you have one, and take time to adjust to the situation. You will probably want to talk to trusted family members and friends for support, but if you feel anxious or fearful, tell your doctor. You may also want to seek professional advice about making changes to your housing arrangements or your finances when you feel ready. The magnitude of change may seem huge, but take a deep breath and start taking steps to make sure you have a healthy pregnancy.

Q I drank and smoked before realizing that I was pregnant. Will that have harmed my baby?

You probably didn't harm your baby if you had a couple of drinks and the occasional cigarette, but you must stop immediately to reduce risk of any damage to you and your baby.

Alcohol and drugs have their greatest effect during organ development, which doesn't begin until week five. As soon as you know you are pregnant, however, you should abstain from all alcohol and stop smoking during pregnancy. If

you drink or smoke heavily and you continue throughout your pregnancy, you are at risk of damaging both your health and that of your baby. Smoking can directly affect the placenta's growth, and in later pregnancy it can reduce the supply of oxygen and nutrients to the baby, resulting in a lower birthweight and more chance of a premature baby. Smoking doubles the risk of stillbirth. Regular or heavy drinking can lead to fetal alcohol syndrome (see p.325), which damages the baby's nervous system and inhibits his ability to thrive after birth.

Q I'm not as happy as I thought I'd be about being pregnant.

Whether planned or not, a pregnancy can raise deep emotional issues that you were not aware of before. You may be facing a whole range of emotions, including disbelief, feeling overwhelmed, and you may be at a loss about what to do next. Give yourself permission to go along with whatever you are feeling for the next few weeks until you have begun to adjust to this new role in life, and don't feel guilty. If you continue to feel negative about the pregnancy, seek support and reassurance from loved ones or speak to your doctor.

Q What if my partner isn't pleased about the pregnancy?

If you are in this situation, accept your partner's feelings and give him plenty of time to adjust to what is, after all, life-changing news. On hearing the news, he may feel upset and angry, and panic, especially if the pregnancy is unplanned. Try not to take his reaction personally. Hopefully it will become a constructive part of processing the news and coming to terms with the future. In the meantime, try to plan some short-term goals that you can enjoy together, or set aside time in your calendar for real time together to build your relationship as a couple.

Taken properly, the combined contraceptive pill is more than 99 percent effective.

WHAT ELSE SHOULD I KNOW?

There is no scientific evidence that the hormones estrogen and progesterone contained in this product affect a developing embryo and fetus.

There is no scientific evidence that the progesterone in this product affects a developing embryo and fetus.

This contains the same hormones as the combined and minipills, so there is no risk to the developing embryo and fetus. Neither does it cause an abortion.

There is no scientific evidence that the progesterone in this product affects a developing embryo and fetus.

There is no scientific evidence that the progesterone in this product affects a developing embryo and fetus. If the implant can't be located and removed, there is no need to worry.

You need to request an ultrasound to rule out an ectopic pregnancy. If the IUD stays in position while you are pregnant, it is usually delivered with the placenta after the birth.

There is no scientific evidence that this product affects a developing embryo and fetus.

You should make an appointment with your doctor promptly: your fallopian tubes are likely to have been damaged by the sterilization procedure and you may be at risk of an ectopic pregnancy (see p.308).